

STATE OF OKLAHOMA

2nd Session of the 60th Legislature (2026)

SUBCOMMITTEE RECOMMENDATION
FOR ENGROSSED

SENATE BILL NO. 706

By: Pugh of the Senate

and

Lowe of the House

SUBCOMMITTEE RECOMMENDATION

An Act relating to schools; amending Section 1, Chapter 493, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 698.4), which relates to the Grow Your Own Educator Program; modifying definition of eligible school district; eliminating references to matching funds; providing option for eligible schools to receive program grants for employees taking an approved alternative certification pathway; updating district and Department reporting dates; allowing tuition and fee reimbursement for employees enrolled in approved alternative certification coursework; providing examples of eligible coursework; requiring the State Board of Education to promulgate rules; and declaring an emergency.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

SECTION 1. AMENDATORY Section 1, Chapter 493, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 698.4), is amended to read as follows:

1 Section 698.4. A. As used in this section, "eligible school
2 district" means a public school district or public school district
3 foundation in this state that has established a program to provide
4 tuition or loan repayment assistance to school district employees
5 who:

6 1. ~~pursue~~ Pursue an undergraduate degree from a teacher
7 preparation program accredited by the Commission for Educational
8 Quality and Accountability leading to a standard teaching
9 certificate; or

10 2. Are enrolled in nondegree-seeking coursework required for
11 completion of an approved alternative certification pathway from a
12 teacher preparation program accredited by the Commission for
13 Educational Quality and Accountability leading to a standard
14 teaching certificate.

15 B. There is hereby created the Grow Your Own Educator Program
16 to provide ~~matching~~ fund grants to eligible school districts. The
17 program shall be established and maintained by the State Department
18 of Education.

19 C. An eligible school district seeking to participate in the
20 Grow Your Own Educator Program shall submit an application in the
21 manner and on a form prescribed by the State Department of
22 Education. The application shall include:

23 1. The amount of ~~matching~~ fund grants requested;

1 2. The position of the employee pursuing an undergraduate
2 degree or alternate certification coursework from a teacher
3 preparation program; and

4 3. The subject area in which the employee is pursuing an
5 undergraduate degree or alternate certification from a teacher
6 preparation program.

7 D. ~~Matching fund~~ Fund grants shall be awarded on a first-come,
8 first-served basis. Grants shall be provided without any limitation
9 other than the amount of funds available in the Grow Your Own
10 Educator Revolving Fund created pursuant to Section 2 of this act
11 and the number of eligible school districts that apply.

12 E. By June 30, ~~2026~~ 2027, and each June 30 thereafter, an
13 eligible school district that receives a ~~matching~~ fund grant
14 pursuant to this section shall electronically submit a report to the
15 State Department of Education that includes:

16 1. A status update on the progress the employee receiving
17 tuition assistance is making in the teacher preparation program in
18 which he or she is enrolled; or

19 2. The employment status of the employee receiving loan
20 repayment assistance.

21 F. By December 31, ~~2026~~ 2027, and each December 31 thereafter,
22 the State Department of Education shall electronically submit a
23 report to the Governor, the President Pro Tempore of the Senate, and
24 the Speaker of the House of Representatives that includes:

1 1. The school district ~~matching~~ fund grant recipients;

2 2. The amount of ~~matching~~ fund grants allocated to each
3 recipient;

4 3. The subject area in which the employee receiving tuition
5 assistance is pursuing an undergraduate degree, or the subject area
6 in which the employee receiving loan repayment assistance has
7 received an undergraduate degree; and

8 4. The information submitted pursuant to subsection E of this
9 section.

10 G. The State Board of Education shall promulgate rules to
11 implement the provisions of this section.

12 H. 1. Employees enrolled in an approved alternative
13 certification pathway as described in subsection A of this section
14 shall be eligible for tuition or course fee reimbursement through
15 the Grow Your Own Educator Program.

16 2. Eligible coursework for alternative certification may
17 include, but is not limited to, classes in classroom management,
18 pedagogy, student assessment, special education, and instructional
19 methodology, as determined by the State Department of Education.

20 3. The State Board of Education shall promulgate rules to
21 identify and approve eligible nondegree-seeking courses and
22 alternative certification programs that qualify under this section.

23 SECTION 2. It being immediately necessary for the preservation
24 of the public peace, health or safety, an emergency is hereby

1 declared to exist, by reason whereof this act shall take effect and
2 be in full force from and after its passage and approval.

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